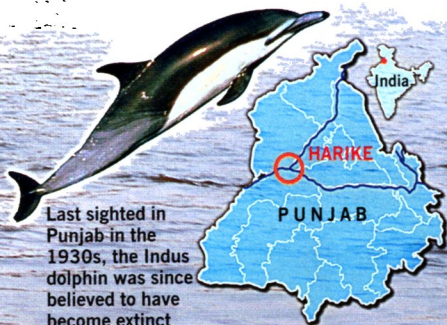


THE INDUS DOLPHIN



Last sighted in Punjab in the 1930s, the Indus dolphin was since believed to have become extinct

- The dolphins feed on small fish, gastropods and insect larvae and weigh up to 150 kg
- With a life span of about 20 years, the river dolphin is docile and prefers to stay in deep water
- Adults are 1.5-2m long, their head shaped like a melon, with a long thin snout armed with up to 130 sharp teeth

MAMMAL MILESTONE: A family of half a dozen dolphins was sighted at two different places upstream of the Beas

ent flows into the Sutlej and the Beas across Punjab every day. While the Sutlej has already turned into a toxic trove and a biological desert, two industries and seven towns discharge their effluents into the Beas.

Pollution is the root cause of another serious problem—the spread of hyacinth, an obnoxious weed which now covers two-thirds of the lake. Indiscriminate fishing, which yields a revenue of Rs 1 crore a year for the Fisheries Department, has also been playing havoc with the habitat of migratory birds, and is now seen as a major threat to the dolphins. Prohibited in 1999, when the sanctuary was declared protected under the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972, fishing continues to thrive in response to the demand for freshwater catch. Much of the degradation has stemmed from poor management. Eight government departments are involved in managing the wetland, with little coordination among them. The funds are meagre and ill-timed. For instance, the State Council of Science and Technology (SCST), the nodal agency, sanctioned Rs 4 lakh for removal of hyacinth in November last year, ignoring the fact that waterfowl migrate to the sanctuary in winter. "We are only focusing on the protection of the wetland while habitat improvement is what it needs," says Rajkumar.

Several plans for improvement are stuck in paperwork. One such plan by the Department of Forest and Wildlife for the development of the Hariki habitat over the next 10 years, entailing a cost of Rs 32 crore, has been gathering dust for over a year. "We will soon formulate an integrated plan," says Neelima Jerath, additional director, SCST. The discovery of the dolphins comes as an excellent opportunity for the authorities to revive eco-tourism and garner funds from international agencies so that Hariki's endangered birds and dolphins no longer remain on a wing and a prayer.

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